

P O L I T I C S

B. Jowett

BOOK I

I • EVERY STATE IS A COMMUNITY OF SOME KIND, and every 1252^{a1}
community is established with a view to some good; for ev-
eryone always acts in order to obtain that which they think
good. But, if all communities aim at some good, the state or
political community, which is the highest of all, and which 5
embraces all the rest, aims at good in a greater degree than
any other, and at the highest good.

Some people think that the qualifications of a statesman,
king, householder, and master are the same, and that they 10
differ, not in kind, but only in the number of their subjects.
For example, the ruler over a few is called a master; over
more, the manager of a household; over a still larger number,
a statesman or king, as if there were no difference between
a great household and a small state. The distinction which
is made between the king and the statesman is as follows:
When the government is personal, the ruler is a king; when,
according to the rules of the political science, the citizens 15
rule and are ruled in turn, then he is called a statesman.

But all this is a mistake, as will be evident to any one who
considers the matter according to the method which has
hitherto guided us. As in other departments of science, so
in politics, the compound should always be resolved into the
simple elements or least parts of the whole. We must there-
fore look at the elements of which the state is composed, in 20
order that we may see in what the different kinds of rule dif-
fer from one another, and whether any scientific result can be
attained about each one of them.

TEXT: A. Dreizehnter, Munich, 1970

2 • He who thus considers things in their first growth and
 25 origin, whether a state or anything else, will obtain the clear-
 est view of them. In the first place there must be a union of
 those who cannot exist without each other; namely, of male
 and female, that the race may continue (and this is a union
 which is formed, not of choice, but because, in common with
 30 other animals and with plants, mankind have a natural desire
 to leave behind them an image of themselves), and of natural
 ruler and subject, that both may be preserved. For that which
 can foresee by the exercise of mind is by nature lord and
 master, and that which can with its body give effect to such
 foresight is a subject, and by nature a slave; hence master and
 slave have the same interest. Now nature has distinguished
 1252^b1 between the female and the slave. For she is not niggardly,
 like the smith who fashions the Delphian knife for many
 uses; she makes each thing for a single use, and every instru-
 ment is best made when intended for one and not for many
 5 uses. But among barbarians no distinction is made between
 women and slaves, because there is no natural ruler among
 them: they are a community of slaves, male and female. That
 is why the poets say,—

It is meet that Hellenes should rule over barbarians;

as if they thought that the barbarian and the slave were by
 nature one.

10 Out of these two relationships the first thing to arise is the
 family, and Hesiod is right when he says,—

First house and wife and an ox for the plough,

15 for the ox is the poor man's slave. The family is the associa-
 tion established by nature for the supply of men's everyday
 wants, and the members of it are called by Charondas, 'com-
 panions of the cupboard', and by Epimenides the Cretan,
 'companions of the manger'. But when several families are
 united, and the association aims at something more than the
 supply of daily needs, the first society to be formed is the vil-
 lage. And the most natural form of the village appears to be

that of a colony from the family, composed of the children and grandchildren, who are said to be ‘suckled with the same milk’. And this is the reason why Hellenic states were originally governed by kings; because the Hellenes were under royal rule before they came together, as the barbarians still are. Every family is ruled by the eldest, and therefore in the colonies of the family the kingly form of government prevailed because they were of the same blood. As Homer says:

Each one gives law to his children and to his wives.

For they lived dispersedly, as was the manner in ancient times. That is why men say that the Gods have a king, because they themselves either are or were in ancient times under the rule of a king. For they imagine not only the forms of the Gods but their ways of life to be like their own.

When several villages are united in a single complete community, large enough to be nearly or quite self-sufficing, the state comes into existence, originating in the bare needs of life, and continuing in existence for the sake of a good life. And therefore, if the earlier forms of society are natural, so is the state, for it is the end of them, and the nature of a thing is its end. For what each thing is when fully developed, we call its nature, whether we are speaking of a man, a horse, or a family. Besides, the final cause and end of a thing is the best, and to be self-sufficing is the end and the best.

Hence it is evident that the state is a creation of nature, and that man is by nature a political animal. And he who by nature and not by mere accident is without a state, is either a bad man or above humanity; he is like the

Tribeless, lawless, hearthless one,

whom Homer denounces—the natural outcast is forthwith a lover of war; he may be compared to an isolated piece at draughts.

Now, that man is more of a political animal than bees or any other gregarious animals is evident. Nature, as we often say, makes nothing in vain, and man is the only animal who has the gift of speech. And whereas mere voice is but an indication

of pleasure or pain, and is therefore found in other animals (for their nature attains to the perception of pleasure and pain and the intimation of them to one another, and no further), the power of speech is intended to set forth the expedient and inexpedient, and therefore likewise the just and the unjust. And it is a characteristic of man that he alone has
 15 any sense of good and evil, of just and unjust, and the like, and the association of living beings who have this sense makes a family and a state.

Further, the state is by nature clearly prior to the family
 20 and to the individual, since the whole is of necessity prior to the part; for example, if the whole body be destroyed, there will be no foot or hand, except homonymously, as we might speak of a stone hand; for when destroyed the hand will be no better than that. But things are defined by their function and power; and we ought not to say that they are the same when they no longer have their proper quality, but only that they
 25 are homonymous. The proof that the state is a creation of nature and prior to the individual is that the individual, when isolated, is not self-sufficing; and therefore he is like a part in relation to the whole. But he who is unable to live in society, or who has no need because he is sufficient for himself, must be either a beast or a god: he is no part of a state. A social in-
 30 stinct is implanted in all men by nature, and yet he who first founded the state was the greatest of benefactors. For man, when perfected, is the best of animals, but, when separated from law and justice, he is the worst of all; since armed injustice is the more dangerous, and he is equipped at birth with arms, meant to be used by intelligence and excellence, which
 35 he may use for the worst ends. That is why, if he has not excellence, he is the most unholy and the most savage of animals, and the most full of lust and gluttony. But justice is the bond of men in states; for the administration of justice, which is the determination of what is just, is the principle of order in political society.

1253^{b1} 3 • Seeing then that the state is made up of households, before speaking of the state we must speak of the manage-

ment of the household. The parts of household management correspond to the persons who compose the household, and a complete household consists of slaves and freemen. Now we should begin by examining everything in its fewest possible elements; and the first and fewest possible parts of a family are master and slave, husband and wife, father and children. We have therefore to consider what each of these three relations is and ought to be:—I mean the relation of master and servant, the marriage relation (the conjunction of man and wife has no name of its own), and thirdly, the paternal relation (this also has no proper name). And there is another element of a household, the so-called art of getting wealth, which, according to some, is identical with household management, according to others, a principal part of it; the nature of this art will also have to be considered by us.

Let us first speak of master and slave, looking to the needs of practical life and also seeking to attain some better theory of their relation than exists at present. For some are of the opinion that the rule of a master is a science, and that the management of a household, and the mastership of slaves, and the political and royal rule, as I was saying at the outset, are all the same. Others affirm that the rule of a master over slaves is contrary to nature, and that the distinction between slave and freeman exists by convention only, and not by nature; and being an interference with nature is therefore unjust.

4 • Property is a part of the household, and the art of acquiring property is a part of the art of managing the household; for no man can live well, or indeed live at all, unless he is provided with necessities. And as in the arts which have a definite sphere the workers must have their own proper instruments for the accomplishment of their work, so it is in the management of a household. Now instruments are of various sorts; some are living, others lifeless; in the rudder, the pilot of a ship has a lifeless, in the look-out man, a living instrument; for in the arts the servant is a kind of instrument. Thus, too, a possession is an instrument for maintaining life.

And so, in the arrangement of the family, a slave is a living possession, and property a number of such instruments; and the servant is himself an instrument for instruments. For if every instrument could accomplish its own work, obeying or anticipating the will of others, like the statues of Daedalus,
 35 or the tripods of Hephaestus, which, says the poet,

of their own accord entered the assembly of the Gods;

if, in like manner, the shuttle would weave and the plectrum touch the lyre, chief workmen would not want servants, nor
 1254^a1 masters slaves. Now the instruments commonly so called are instruments of production, whilst a possession is an instrument of action. From a shuttle we get something else besides the use of it, whereas of a garment or of a bed there is only
 5 the use. Further, as production and action are different in kind, and both require instruments, the instruments which they employ must likewise differ in kind. But life is action and not production, and therefore the slave is the minister of action. Again, a possession is spoken of as a part is spoken of; for the part is not only a part of something else, but
 10 wholly belongs to it; and this is also true of a possession. The master is only the master of the slave; he does not belong to him, whereas the slave is not only the slave of his master, but wholly belongs to him. Hence we see what is the nature and office of a slave; he who is by nature not his own but another's
 15 man, is by nature a slave; and he may be said to be another's man who, being a slave, is also a possession. And a possession may be defined as an instrument of action, separable from the possessor.

5 • But is there any one thus intended by nature to be a slave, and for whom such a condition is expedient and right, or rather is not all slavery a violation of nature?

20 There is no difficulty in answering this question, on grounds both of reason and of fact. For that some should rule and others be ruled is a thing not only necessary, but expedient; from the hour of their birth, some are marked out for subjection, others for rule.

And there are many kinds both of rulers and subjects
 (and that rule is the better which is exercised over better 25
 subjects—for example, to rule over men is better than to
 rule over wild beasts; for the work is better which is executed
 by better workmen, and where one man rules and another
 is ruled, they may be said to have a work); for in all things
 which form a composite whole and which are made up of 30
 parts, whether continuous or discrete, a distinction between
 the ruling and the subject element comes to light. Such a
 duality exists in living creatures, originating from nature as
 a whole; even in things which have no life there is a ruling
 principle, as in a musical mode. But perhaps this is matter
 for a more popular investigation. A living creature consists
 in the first place of soul and body, and of these two, the one 35
 is by nature the ruler and the other the subject. But then we
 must look for the intentions of nature in things which retain
 their nature, and not in things which are corrupted. And
 therefore we must study the man who is in the most perfect
 state both of body and soul, for in him we shall see the true
 relation of the two; although in bad or corrupted natures 1254^b1
 the body will often appear to rule over the soul, because they
 are in an evil and unnatural condition. At all events we may
 firstly observe in living creatures both a despotical and a con-
 stitutional rule; for the soul rules the body with a despotical 5
 rule, whereas the intellect rules the appetites with a constitu-
 tional and royal rule. And it is clear that the rule of the soul
 over the body, and of the mind and the rational element over
 the passionate, is natural and expedient; whereas the equal-
 ity of the two or the rule of the inferior is always hurtful. The
 same holds good of animals in relation to men; for tame 10
 animals have a better nature than wild and all tame animals
 are better off when they are ruled by man; for then they are
 preserved. Again, the male is by nature superior, and the fe-
 male inferior; and the one rules, and the other is ruled; this
 principle, of necessity, extends to all mankind. Where then 15
 there is such a difference as that between soul and body, or
 between men and animals (as in the case of those whose busi-
 ness is to use their body, and who can do nothing better), the